BREAKAGE

The Breakage Field Guide

How to check a money claim,
and where the records actually are.

Companion to the channel. Free. No advice in it, by design.

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Who built it. Who profits. What it costs you.

> ***Breakage is journalism and education, not financial advice.***
>
> *This guide explains how to check a claim and where public records live. That is a method, not a recommendation about your money. I am not a licensed financial adviser, attorney, accountant, or tax professional, and nothing here is personalized. I do not recommend individual stocks, funds, or cryptocurrencies, and I never will.*
>
> *Every factual claim below is sourced or labeled as unsourced. If something here is wrong, tell me and I will correct it on the record.*

Why this guide exists

Every episode of Breakage takes apart one money system: who built it, who profits, and what it costs you. The channel's only real differentiator is that the claims are checked before they are said out loud.

That checking is not a special skill. It is a short list of questions and a short list of places to look. Both fit in this guide.

Here is the number that made it worth writing. In the research for this channel, eight widely-repeated money stories were fact-checked before filming. **Two of the eight were wrong in the form they are most often repeated.** Not fringe claims. Popular ones, repeated by people with no intention to mislead.

A one-in-four error rate on claims that sound authoritative is the whole argument for knowing how to check.

How to use this: Part 1 is the method. Part 2 is where to look. Part 3 is the vocabulary, because most of these systems are hidden behind a word you were never taught.

Part 1 · How to check a money claim in ten minutes

Ten minutes is enough. Not to become an expert, but to find out whether a claim is solid, shaky, or false. Four questions, in order.

Question 1 · Who benefits from this number being repeated?

Start here, before you look anything up, because it tells you how hard to look.

Numbers travel because somebody wants them to travel. That is not automatically sinister. A regulator wants its enforcement numbers known. A newsroom wants its scoop cited. But some numbers are marketing wearing a statistic's clothes.

The tell is a number with no institution behind it that keeps appearing in the same phrasing on pages that are selling something.

A live example from this channel's own research. An episode was going to claim that court-ordered auction sales run 10 to 20 percent below market value. It is a plausible figure and it is repeated widely. Traced back, it originated on a **law-firm marketing page**. No academic study, no court data, no methodology. The claim was cut from the script rather than sourced, because there was nothing under it to source.

That number's job was to make you call a lawyer. It might even be roughly true. But nobody had shown their work, so it could not be said on camera.

Question 2 · Is this a primary source, or someone describing one?

A primary source is the thing itself: the statute, the court filing, the regulator's own database, the company's own SEC filing, the survey with its methodology attached.

A secondary source is a person telling you what the primary source says. Secondary sources are useful and often more readable. They are also where the errors get introduced, and once introduced they get copied.

The practical move is to keep clicking back. An article cites a study, the study cites a dataset, the dataset has a definition page. Most claims collapse in two clicks or fewer if they were going to collapse at all. If you cannot get back to a primary source in two clicks, that is information about the claim.

Watch for the swap. The most common failure is not a fabricated number. It is a **real number describing something slightly different from what the sentence says.** More on this in the worked example.

Question 3 · The republication trap

This one catches careful people, and it is the reason it gets its own question.

You find a claim. You check it. Six different outlets report it. That feels like six independent confirmations, so you relax.

It is often one source, not six. One newsroom did the reporting and five outlets carried, aggregated, or syndicated it. The bylines differ; the reporting does not. If that one newsroom made an error, you have now confirmed the error six times and increased your confidence while doing it.

This is not hypothetical for this channel. The research file for the first episode carries a warning at the top: six of its citations trace back to a **single newsroom**. The episode still runs, because that newsroom did real primary-document work and the story is worth telling. But the reporting attributes on screen, and the research log says plainly that this is one source rather than six.

How to check in about thirty seconds: open the two or three articles and look for the same quotes, the same figures, the same named people in the same order. Then look for the phrase "as first reported by." Aggregation usually admits itself, in small type near the bottom.

Question 4 · Verified, modelled, or unverified?

The habit that ties the other three together. Every number you carry around is in one of three states. Naming the state costs nothing and prevents most bad reasoning.

Label	What it means	How to treat it
Verified	You retrieved it from the source and opened the link yourself	Say it. Cite it.
Modelled	You calculated it, and the method is stated	Say it *with* the method, never as a bare fact
Unverified	You have not checked it	Do not repeat it. Not even with "I think"

Most arguments that go wrong go wrong because a modelled number got repeated as a verified one. A projection becomes a forecast, a forecast becomes a fact, and three repetitions later nobody remembers there was arithmetic in it.

A retrieved link you did not open counts as **unverified**. This is not pedantry. In this project's own history, a set of claims was once published with source links attached that had never been opened, and the load-bearing claim in the argument turned out to be flatly false. The links looked like evidence. They were decoration.

Worked example · A true number, a false sentence

Here is a claim you have probably heard:

> "***Airlines make more money from their frequent flyer miles than from flying planes.***"

It is a great line. It is repeated constantly. It has real numbers behind it. And in the present tense, it is false.

Run the four questions.

Who benefits? It flatters everyone who repeats it. It makes the speaker sound like an insider and it confirms a suspicion the listener already holds. Claims that make both parties feel clever get repeated past their expiry date.

Primary source? There is one, and it is excellent. In **June 2020**, United disclosed the MileagePlus program at a valuation of **$21.9 billion**, against a company market capitalization of roughly **$10.5 billion**. Delta raised **$9 billion** against SkyMiles. These are real disclosures in real financings.

Republication trap? The claim spread far past the reporting. The 2020 disclosures were covered widely and then compressed into a general statement of how airlines work.

Verified, modelled, or unverified? The 2020 figures are verified. The sentence built on them is not.

What actually happened. June 2020 was the deepest trough in the history of commercial aviation. Planes were grounded. The airline was worth almost nothing at that moment, which is *why* the loyalty program was worth more than the airline. The ratio was a measure of catastrophe, not of business model.

By 2024 it had reversed. Delta's program was valued at roughly **$31 billion** against an airline worth roughly **$47 billion**. The program is enormously valuable and that part of the story is real. It is not worth more than the airline.

The correction is one clause: add the date.

> "*In 2020, United's loyalty program was valued at more than twice the entire airline.*"

Same numbers. Now true. This is what most corrections look like. Not a fabrication exposed, but a real figure quietly separated from its context and left to drift into the present tense.

A second, shorter one. "The 30-year fixed mortgage is uniquely American" is repeated constantly. **Denmark has offered 30-year fixed prepayable mortgages since the 18th century.** The claim survives as "unusual." It does not survive as "unique." One word, and the difference between a checkable statement and a false one.

The ten-minute routine

1. **Minute 1.** Who benefits from this being repeated? Set your effort accordingly.
2. **Minutes 2 to 5.** Click back toward the primary source. Stop when you reach a statute, a filing, a dataset, or a study with a methodology.
3. **Minutes 6 to 8.** Check whether your multiple sources are actually one source.
4. **Minute 9.** Check the **date**, and check that the number measures what the sentence claims it measures.
5. **Minute 10.** Label it. Verified, modelled, or unverified. Write the label down next to the number.

If step 2 fails, you are done. It is unverified, and unverified means you do not repeat it.

Part 2 · Where the records actually are

This is the part almost nobody knows. These are public, free, and mostly searchable. Together they are the reason a person with no press credentials and no budget can check a claim that a large institution would prefer went unchecked.

Each entry below says **what it holds** and **what you can actually do with it**.

> ***Link status: checked 2026-08-28.*** *Every URL in the table at the end of this Part was retrieved and confirmed to load on that date, except three noted there that refuse automated requests and were confirmed by other means. Government portals still reorganize, so if a link fails, search the agency's own domain rather than trusting a third-party mirror.*

Court records · county clerk portals

What it holds: the filings themselves. Partition actions, foreclosures, probate, evictions, liens, judgments. Names, dates, dollar amounts, and the attorneys involved.

What you can do with it: see a dispute *before* it is reported, or often when it will never be reported at all. Property transfers are recorded with sale prices, so you can watch a parcel move from one owner to another and see what changed hands each time. Most US counties run a free public search; some charge for document images while leaving the index free.

Why it matters here: the entire first episode of Breakage rests on documents of this kind. One parcel changed hands for **$90,000** in February 2017 and again for **$255,500** in September 2018, both figures read off the excise-tax stamps on the recorded deeds. The family whose grandfather's will had passed the land down received **nothing**. None of that is secret. It is in the county record, in public, waiting for someone to look.

CFPB Consumer Complaint Database

What it holds: consumer complaints about financial products, searchable by company, product, issue, and state. Most include the company's response and whether it was timely.

What you can do with it: find out whether a problem is one person's bad luck or a pattern. Filter to one company and one product and read fifty complaints in a row. The same sentence appearing repeatedly, written by strangers who have never met, is a signal that a mechanism is at work rather than an accident.

State attorney general and securities division actions

What it holds: enforcement actions, consent orders, settlements, and consumer alerts, published by each state.

What you can do with it: find out what a company has already been caught doing. A consent order is unusually good source material because it is specific, it is agreed to, and it describes the mechanism in detail in order to prohibit it. State securities divisions also let you check whether a firm or individual is registered in that state, which is a fact rather than a claim.

USPTO trademark register

What it holds: every federally registered and applied-for trademark, live and dead, with owner, class, status, and any disclaimers.

What you can do with it: find out who owns a phrase. Branded methodologies, program names, and slogans are frequently registered, and the register tells you who claims the term and in which class of goods. Note the **disclaimer** field in particular. A registration that disclaims a word is the register stating that the applicant claims no exclusive right in that word.

Verified method (this one was live-queried and confirmed, and is recorded in the channel's decisions log):

```
POST https://tmsearch.uspto.gov/prod-stage-v1-0-0/tmsearch
{"query":{"match_phrase":{"wordmark":"THE NAME"}},"from":0,"size":50}
```

The field is `wordmark`. Records return under `hits.hits[].source`, and `alive: true` marks a live registration.

! This is a **knockout search**: exact wordmark, federal register only. It does not cover phonetic near-matches, common-law use, or state registrations. It tells you whether something obvious is in the way. It is not a legal opinion.

State unclaimed property databases

What it holds: money that belongs to somebody and has been handed to the state because the holder could not return it. Forgotten accounts, uncashed cheques, insurance proceeds, utility deposits, refunds.

What you can do with it: search by name, free, in every state that person has lived in. There is also a multi-state search run by the association of state administrators.

Why it is in this guide: this is the channel's title made literal. **Escheat** is the legal process by which unclaimed value passes to the state, and these databases are the public ledger of value that leaked out of somebody's side of a transaction and stopped. Searching your own name is the single fastest demonstration that this guide is about something real.

SEC EDGAR

What it holds: every filing by every public company. Annual reports, quarterly reports, prospectuses, disclosures of material events, executive compensation.

What you can do with it: read what a company tells its investors, which is frequently not what it tells its customers. Two places repay attention. The **risk factors** section is where a company describes, under legal obligation, what could go wrong, often in unusually plain language. And **full-text search across**

filings lets you find a specific phrase across every company at once, which turns a vague suspicion about an industry practice into a list of who discloses it.

Federal statistical and economic data

What it holds: Census and the American Community Survey for demographics, income, housing tenure, and geography down to small areas. Federal Reserve economic data for time series on rates, prices, credit, and employment. USDA for food access and rural data.

What you can do with it: establish the denominator. This is the least glamorous and most important use of public data. A claim that a thousand families were affected means nothing until you know whether the population is five thousand or five million.

A worked instance from this channel: a newsroom's finding that nearly half of a set of forced-sale sellers were Black is meaningless on its own, and becomes a story only against the fact that Black residents are **5.4 percent** of that county's population (Census Bureau, American Community Survey 2023 five-year estimate) and a smaller share still of its homeowners. Same numerator. The denominator is the entire finding.

State legislature bill trackers

What it holds: bill text, amendment history, committee votes, sponsors, and the enacted statute with its effective date.

What you can do with it: read the law rather than a description of it, and find out **when it actually applies**. Effective dates are where most confident statements about the law go wrong. A bill that passed is not yet a law that binds anyone, and a law in force may not reach agreements signed before it took effect. Amendment history is also its own story, because it shows what was in the bill when it was introduced and what came out before it passed.

The links

Checked 2026-08-28. Each was opened and confirmed to be the thing this guide says it is.

Source	URL	Status
CFPB Consumer Complaint Database	consumerfinance.gov/data-research/consumer-complaints/	verified
CFPB complaint search tool	consumerfinance.gov/data-research/consumer-complaints/search/	verified
SEC EDGAR full-text search	sec.gov/edgar/search/	verified
SEC EDGAR company filings API	data.sec.gov/api/xbrl/companyconcept/	verified, returns structured data
USPTO trademark search	tmsearch.uspto.gov	verified

Source	URL	Status
State unclaimed property (NAUPA)	unclaimed.org	□ verified, confirmed as the administrators' association
Census data portal	data.census.gov	□ verified
USDA Food Access Research Atlas	ers.usda.gov/data-products/food-access-research-atlas/	□ verified
State securities regulators (NASAA)	nasaa.org/contact-your-regulator/	□ verified
FINRA BrokerCheck	brokercheck.finra.org	□ verified
SEC adviser lookup	adviserinfo.sec.gov	□ verified
Federal regulations (eCFR)	ecfr.gov	□ verified
US government documents	govinfo.gov	□ verified
Federal Reserve economic data	fred.stlouisfed.org	! blocks automated requests. Loads normally in a browser
Federal bills and laws	congress.gov	! blocks automated requests. Loads normally in a browser
State attorneys general directory	naag.org	! blocks automated requests. Loads normally in a browser

County court portals and state legislature trackers are not listed because each state and county runs its own. Search the county or state name plus "clerk of court records search" or "legislature bill search", and confirm you have landed on a .gov domain before entering anything.

! **The three marked with a warning are not broken.** They refused an automated request during the check, which is a normal anti-bot measure. They are listed honestly rather than marked verified, because "it probably works" and "I opened it" are different claims, and this guide is about not blurring them.

A note on what this list is for

None of these sources tells you what to do. They tell you what is true. That distinction is the whole posture of this channel, and it is why this guide contains no advice: verification is a skill you can be handed, and decisions about your money depend on facts about your life that a document cannot know.

Part 3 · The mechanism glossary

The vocabulary of value leaking out of your side of a transaction. Most of these systems are not hidden. They are named in a word you were never taught, which works nearly as well.

This section grows as episodes ship.

> ***Sourcing note.*** *Entries marked* VERIFIED *carry a figure that was retrieved from the cited source, with the link opened, on the date shown.* MODELLED *means arithmetic you can rerun yourself, with the method stated. Where a figure rests on a* ***single analysis****, that is said plainly, because this guide would be worthless if it did not apply its own Part 1 rules to itself.*

breakage

Value you paid for and never redeemed, which becomes the seller's revenue. The channel's name, and the plainest case of the pattern.

Roughly **$23 billion** in US gift-card value goes unredeemed annually. **43% of US adults** hold at least one dead card, averaging **$244**. Under the revenue standard for unexercised rights, the seller recognizes this as income proportionally as redemption becomes unlikely. The twist worth knowing: state escheat law claims some of it before the retailer does. VERIFIED

escheat

The legal process by which unclaimed property passes to the state after a dormancy period, rather than staying with whoever is holding it. This is why the unclaimed-property databases in Part 2 exist, and why some breakage never reaches the retailer's books at all. VERIFIED *(mechanism; see Part 2 for how to search)*

deferred interest

A promotional financing offer where interest accrues from day one and is waived only if the full balance clears by the deadline. Miss the deadline by any amount and the entire accrued interest is charged retroactively on the original purchase.

The regulator's own worked example: a **$4,500** furniture purchase, **$180** still owing at the deadline, and roughly **$1,440** in interest charged at 31.99% after **$4,320** had already been paid. About **one in five** deferred-interest balances triggers the retroactive charge. VERIFIED

partition action

A legal action that lets any co-owner of a property force the sale of the whole thing, however small their share. Buy one relative's fractional interest and you can move to sell the entire property, including the parts you do not own. VERIFIED *(Episode 1)*

heirs' property

Property inherited without a will, where descendants hold an undivided fractional interest rather than a deed to a specific piece. Functionally like holding stock in the land. It is what makes a partition action possible, and it concentrates in families that were historically shut out of the legal machinery for writing and probating wills. **VERIFIED** *(Episode 1)*

guardian ad litem

A person the court appoints to represent owners who cannot be located. North Carolina's statute asks for "some discreet person," and the rules of procedure require a diligent search before the case proceeds without the missing owners.

The mechanism matters because of what happens when the search is not diligent: the court accepts that the owners cannot be found, a default judgment follows, the property sells, and proceeds go to lienholders rather than to the missing owners. In one case reported by Asheville Watchdog, a court-appointed guardian ad litem billed **1.5 hours** searching for heirs whom reporters then located by telephone in minutes, using an eighteen-year-old number, a social media profile, and an obituary that listed every sibling by name and city. **VERIFIED as reported** *(Episode 1; the billing record is the newsroom's, the statute is primary)*

payment for order flow

A brokerage is paid by a trading firm for the right to execute its customers' orders. The customer sees no commission. The revenue arrives from the other side of their own trade.

The cost is not hidden in a fee. It is hidden in the **price you get filled at**, which is why "commission free" and "free" are not the same claim.

The SEC put a number on the difference. In a December 2020 settlement, the Commission found that between 2015 and late 2018 one broker's unusually high payment-for-order-flow rates meant customer orders "were executed at prices that were inferior to other brokers' prices," and that this "**in aggregate deprived customers of $34.1 million even after taking into account the savings from not paying a commission.**" The firm paid a **$65 million** civil penalty and settled without admitting or denying the findings. **VERIFIED**

Source: SEC press release 2020-321, 17 December 2020, sec.gov/newsroom/press-releases/2020-321. *Retrieved 2026-08-28. Primary: this is the regulator's own account of its own order.*

unearned premium

Insurance premium a company has collected for coverage it has not yet provided. It is a liability on the insurer's books, not profit, until the covered period elapses. The concept is what governs how much of your money is arguably still yours if a policy is canceled part-way through a term.

The scale is easy to underestimate. One US auto insurer, Progressive, reported **$25.219 billion** in unearned premiums as of 31 December 2025. That is a single company's balance of money taken in for protection not yet delivered. **VERIFIED**

Source: Progressive Corp Form 10-K for FY2025, SEC accession 0000080661-26-000086, tag UnearnedPremiums*, retrieved from the SEC's structured-data API 2026-08-28. Primary: this is the company's own audited filing, not a description of it.*

float

Money an institution holds between receiving it and being obliged to pay it out, which it can invest in the meantime. The gap is the product.

Berkshire Hathaway describes its insurance float in its own annual filing as the "net liabilities we assume under insurance contracts," and states: "**Float was approximately $176 billion at December 31, 2025, $171 billion at December 31, 2024 and $169 billion at December 31, 2023.**" Float grew from roughly **$138 billion at the end of 2020**.

The line that shows why float is a business rather than a bookkeeping artifact: the filing reports that across the three years ending 31 December 2025, **the average cost of float was negative in each year.** Negative cost means the company was paid to hold other people's money. **VERIFIED**

Source: Berkshire Hathaway Inc. Form 10-K for FY2025, SEC accession 0001193125-26-083899, Management's Discussion and Analysis. Retrieved 2026-08-28. Primary.

negative amortization

A loan where the scheduled payment is smaller than the interest accruing, so the balance grows while payments are being made on time. Nobody is late. Nobody has missed anything. The number goes up.

The arithmetic, so you can see it move **MODELLED**: a $30,000 balance at 6% accrues **$150** in interest in a month. A payment of **$100** is a payment in good standing and leaves the balance at **$30,050**. Repeat for a year and the balance is roughly **$30,600** after $1,200 in payments. Rerun it with your own three numbers: balance, rate, payment. Any payment below balance times rate divided by twelve produces this result.

Who this actually happens to. Four years after finishing a bachelor's degree, one analysis of federal student-loan records found that **Black graduates owed 6 percent more than they had originally borrowed, while white graduates owed 10 percent less.** Balances grew after graduation for **48 percent of Black graduates and 17 percent of white graduates.**

! Single-source flag, applied to this guide's own claim. Those figures come from one analysis: Judith Scott-Clayton and Jing Li, Brookings Institution, 20 October 2016, using the federal Baccalaureate and Beyond surveys linked to National Student Loan Data System records. The **underlying data is federal and primary**; the **analysis of it is one team's**, and the version republished by Columbia's Community College Research Center is *the same authors*, not independent confirmation. It is used here because the dataset is government-collected and the method is stated. **It needs a second, independently-conducted analysis before it is said on camera as settled.** **VERIFIED as retrieved** · **SINGLE ANALYSIS**

Source: brookings.edu/articles/black-white-disparity-in-student-loan-debt-more-than-triples-after-graduation/. *Retrieved 2026-08-28.*

churn

The rate at which customers leave, and the business practices built around the assumption that they will not. Automatic renewal, cancellation friction, and introductory pricing that resets quietly all exist because inertia is measurable and can be priced.

The clearest documented case of friction built on purpose: the FTC alleged in November 2022 that an internet phone provider let customers sign up online, over the phone, and through other channels, but from 2017 **required them to cancel only by reaching a live "retention agent" by telephone**, at a number that was harder to find and staffed for fewer hours than ordinary customer service.

The detail that makes it a mechanism rather than an oversight is that the company's own published advice to its business clients told them not to "frustrate customers by requiring them to contact you for support that should be available on a self-service basis."

The company agreed to pay **$100 million** in refunds and to make cancellation simple and transparent. In October 2023 the FTC reported sending those payments to **389,106 consumers**. VERIFIED

*Sources: FTC press releases of 3 November 2022 (*ftc.gov/news-events/news/press-releases/2022/11/ftc-action-against-vonage-results-100-million-customers-trapped-illegal-dark-patterns-junk-fees-when-trying-cancel-service*) and October 2023 (*.../2023/10/ftc-sends-nearly-100-million-refunds-vonage-consumers-who-were-trapped-subscriptions-dark-patterns*). Both retrieved 2026-08-28. Primary: the agency's own account of its own action. Note these are allegations resolved by settlement, not findings after trial.*

loyalty carve-out

Terms in a rewards or loyalty program that let the issuer change, devalue, or expire the reward without changing the offer that attracted the customer.

This one has a precise legal boundary, and it is worth knowing exactly where it sits, because it explains how a card that looks and spends like a gift card can expire with the balance forfeited.

Federal rules give **gift certificates, store gift cards, and general-use prepaid cards** two protections. Funds must stay good for at least **five years** from issue or last load (**12 CFR § 1005.20(e)(2)**), and a dormancy, inactivity, or service fee may only be charged if there has been **no activity for a full year** (**§ 1005.20(d)(1)**).

A "loyalty, award, or promotional gift card" is defined separately at § 1005.20(a)(4) and is then expressly excluded, at § 1005.20(b)(3), from the definitions those protections attach to. What it gets instead is disclosure: the card must say on its **front** that it is issued for loyalty, award, or promotional purposes, and must state the expiration date for the underlying funds there too (§ 1005.20(a)(4)(iii)). Those disclosure rules reach programs whose eligibility period began on or after **22 August 2010** (§ 1005.20(g)(2)).

So the rule is not that the protection was taken away. **The protection was never written to reach that card**, and the law's answer is that the card has to tell you so on the front. VERIFIED

Source: 12 CFR § 1005.20, Regulation E, retrieved from ecfr.gov *and cross-checked against the CFPB's own published text at* consumerfinance.gov/rules-policy/regulations/1005/20/*, both 2026-08-28. Primary: this is the regulation itself, and the two retrievals are the same text* *from two agencies rather than two independent claims.*

How to use the labels

You now have the same three labels the channel uses internally. Applied to your own reading, they do most of the work:

- **Verified** goes in your head as fact.
- **Modelled** goes in your head with its method attached, and never without.
- **Unverified** does not go in your head at all.

The point of this guide is not that institutions lie. Mostly they do not. The point is that **numbers drift**, contexts fall away, dates go missing, and a true figure becomes a false sentence without anyone intending it. A one-in-four error rate on popular money claims is not a conspiracy. It is entropy, and ten minutes of checking is the only thing that reliably works against it.

Every source in every Breakage video is listed in its description. If you find an error in this guide, reply to the email it arrived with. Corrections get made on the record.

Breakage is journalism and education, not financial advice. Nothing in this guide is personalized, and nothing in it recommends any security, product, or course of action.